How does this even work?

Queens example

Solution/1.

Base: empty list []

Recursive: on list [[X,Y]|R]

True if
1.) solution(R)
2.) member(Y,[1,2,3,4,5])
3.) noattack([X,Y], R)

solution(R) checks that the rest of the queens' placement is valid.

Then
member(Y,[1,2,3,4,5]) assigns the queen a row value

noattack ensures this placed queen doesn't attack any other queen.

noattack checks whether the head of the remaining list conflicts with this queen.

Then it recurses to check if the rest of queens after the head are valid.

Now for the knight example...